

A Practical Guide from DigiLabs

Every year, millions of phones, laptops, and old TVs end up in the regular trash — where they leak heavy metals into soil and water, and where any data still on them is never truly gone. This guide walks through the basics: what counts as e-waste, how to protect your data first, and how to get it to a responsible recycler.

1. What Counts as E-Waste?

Anything with a plug, battery, or circuit board: computers, laptops, tablets, phones, monitors, TVs, printers, routers, cables, chargers, game consoles, and small appliances. If it needed electricity to run, it needs to be recycled — not thrown in the trash.

2. Protect Your Data First

- Back up anything you want to keep — photos, documents, contacts — to a cloud account or another device.
- Sign out of accounts (email, cloud storage, app stores) and remove the device from any "Find My" or MDM service.
- Don't rely on a factory reset alone for drives that held sensitive financial, medical, or business data — ask your recycler whether they provide certified data destruction.
- Keep any paperwork (like a Certificate of Destruction) as proof your data was properly wiped.

3. Sort Before You Recycle

Category	Examples	Notes
Data-bearing devices	Computers, phones, drives, tablets	Wipe or destroy data first
Screens	Monitors, TVs, laptops	Contain materials that need special handling
Small electronics	Chargers, cables, routers, remotes	Can usually go straight to recycling
Batteries	Loose batteries, battery packs	Recycle separately — never in regular trash

4. Choose a Responsible Recycler

- Look for a recycler who documents chain of custody and provides a Certificate of Destruction for data-bearing devices.
- Ask what happens after pickup — is it resold, refurbished, or broken down for materials responsibly?
- Avoid anyone who can't tell you where the equipment actually goes.

5. DigiLabs Makes It Easy

DigiLabs handles residential, commercial, and municipal e-waste pickup and drop-off across Broward, Miami-Dade, and Palm Beach counties — with NIST 800-88 compliant data destruction and a Certificate of Destruction for every job. We also turn recovered components into hands-on STEM education kits for South Florida students through DigiLabs TechTank.

Ready to recycle or donate a device? Call **754-274-6614** to schedule a pickup or drop-off, or visit **digi-labs.org**.

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